



Gabon

Gabon is a former French colony straddling the equator on Africa's west coast. Independent since 1960, it returned to multiparty politics in 1990, after 22 years of one-party rule.



GEOGRAPHY

Low plateaus and mountains lie beyond the coastal strip. Two-thirds of the land is covered by rainforest.



CLIMATE

Hot and tropical, with little distinction between seasons. Cold Benguela current cools the coast.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Some 40 different languages are spoken. The Fang, who live mainly in the north, are the largest ethnic group, but have yet to gain control of the government. Oil wealth has led to the growth of an affluent middle class, but one in three people still lives in poverty. Menial jobs are done by immigrant workers. Education follows the French system. With 85% of people living in towns, Gabon is one of Africa's most urbanized countries. The government is encouraging population growth.



THE ECONOMY

Oil accounts for 80% of exports, but reserves are dwindling; not much post-oil planning. High debt problem. Tropical hardwoods and manganese.



INSIGHT: *Libreville was founded as a settlement for freed French slaves in 1849*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Gabonese Republic

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Libreville

POPULATION: 1.47 million

TOTAL AREA: 103,346 sq. miles
(267,667 sq. km)

DENSITY: 15 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Fang, French*, Punu, other

RELIGIONS: Christian (mainly Roman Catholic) 55%, traditional beliefs 40%, other 4%, Muslim 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Fang 26%, Shira-punu 24%, other 24%, foreign 15%, Nzabi-duma 11%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: CFA franc = 100 centimes